

UNIVERSITY OF ESSEX

Third Year Examinations 2001

SC301A: CURRENT DISPUTES IN SOCIOLOGY: SOCIOLOGICAL ANALYSIS III

Time allowed: 3 hours

Candidates must answer three questions:

one from Section A, one from Section B, and the third from either Section

The paper consists of 11 questions

Please do not leave your seat unless you are given permission by an invigilator

Do not communicate in any way with any other candidate in the examination room.

Do not open the question paper until told to do so.

All answers must be written in the answer book(s) provided and not on rough paper.

At the end of the examination, remain seated until your answer book(s) have been collected and you have been told you may leave.

Leave your scrap paper on the desk when you leave the examination room.

Section A

1. '...the new sociology [positivism] is to tie itself to the facts of the existing social order and, though it will not reject the need for correction and improvement, it will exclude any move to overthrow or negate that order. As a result, the conceptual interest of the positive sociology is to be apologetic and justificatory.' (H. Marcuse)

What is positivism, and can it be defended against this criticism?

2. **EITHER:**

- (a) '...whereas in the case of the natural scientist we have to deal with only one set of rules, namely those governing the scientist's investigation itself, here what the sociologist is studying, as well as his study of it, is a human activity, and is therefore carried on according to rules. And it is these rules which govern the sociologist's investigation...' (Peter Winch)

If we accepted this, in what ways would it affect sociological research?

OR

- (b) 'Seriously to study another way of life is necessarily to seek to extend our own – not simply to bring the other way within the existing boundaries of our own'. (P. Winch). Discuss.

3. Both positivists and critical realists argue for the possibility of a scientific approach to sociology. Discuss with reference to either (a) positivism or (b) critical realism.
4. Explain the relationships between power, interests and knowledge in ONE of the following:
 - a. Foucault
 - b. Habermas
 - c. Feminist Epistemologies
5. How, if at all, has this course added to your understanding of a sociological issue or debate, which you have encountered in another course?

Section B

6. **EITHER:**

- (a) What are the political dangers of essentialist concepts of identity?

OR

- (b) What are the political implications of Butler's idea that there is no basis to unite women around the concept of 'sex'?

7. Would you agree with Giddens that the 'reflexive project of the self' is a central problem and preoccupation for modern individuals?
8. What grounds does Baudrillard give for claiming the 'death of the social'?

9. What are the political implications of the notion that “All that was once directly lived has become mere representation?” (G. Debord)
10. In what ways has knowledge become central to the organization of ‘post-industrial societies’?
11. ‘Science wars’ is the name given to the controversy between natural and social scientists with regard to the relationship between science and truth. Discuss the implications of current sociological approaches to the natural sciences as cultural and social phenomena.

END OF PAPER